

Eugnostos the Blessed and The Sophia of Jesus Christ

Codex Reference: III,3; V,1; III,4; BG 8502,3

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Editor's Introduction

Eugnostos begins as a formal letter written by a teacher to his disciples and subsequently shifts to take on qualities of a revelation discourse. It is without apparent Christian influence. With some minor omissions and one major one, it was used by a Christian gnostic editor as he composed *The Sophia of Jesus Christ*. In form, *Soph. Jes. Chr.* is a revelation discourse given by the risen Christ in response to the questions of his disciples. Thus the placing of the two tractates together in the present edition allows one to see the process by which a non-Christian tractate was modified and transformed into a Christian gnostic one. On the basis of the model provided by these two tractates, scholars have conjectured that the same process may have been responsible for other Christian gnostic writings, such as *The Gospel of the Egyptians* and *The Apocryphon of John*.

Eugnostos seems to be directed to a general audience interested in certain religious-philosophical problems. *Soph. Jes. Chr.* was directed to an audience for whom Christianity was an added element in their religious environment. The audience may have been made up of non-Christian Gnostics who already knew the tractate *Eugnostos*. By connecting Christ, in *Soph. Jes. Chr.*, with the prediction at the end of *Eugnostos* (90,6–11), the editor may have hoped to persuade them that Christ was the latest incarnation of the gnostic savior. Or the audience may have consisted of non-gnostic Christians, and the editor may have wanted to persuade them that the religion revealed by Christ was gnostic Christianity. Perhaps the editor had both groups in mind.

The main intent of *Eugnostos* appears to have been to assert and describe the existence of an invisible, supercelestial region beyond the visible world—a region not reflected in the speculations of philosophers (whose views, as they are described, resemble those of Stoics, Epicureans, and Babylonian astrologers). Ruling that region is a hierarchy of five principal divine beings: Unbegotten Father; his reflection, called Self-Father; Self-Father's hypostatized power, Immortal Man, who is androgynous; Immortal Man's androgynous son, Son of Man; and Son of Man's androgynous son, the Savior. The names of the female aspects of the last three include the term Sophia. These divine beings each have their own sphere or aeon, and numerous attendant and subordinate beings. A special group, called "the generation over whom there is no kingdom among the kingdoms that exist," has its origin and true home with Unbegotten Father (75,12–19). A second group of six divine beings spring from the first five. These are said to resemble the first. Ineffable joy and unutterable jubilation characterize existence in the supercelestial region; and from there come patterns or types for subsequent creations. Following a summary passage (85,9–21), the tractate concludes with an appendix dealing with the realm of Immortal Man, which is our aeon. *Eugnostos* shows the influence of the transcendent realm upon this world. With one brief exception (85,8), which is probably an editorial addition, the influence is benign. *Eugnostos*, then, cannot be considered gnostic in any classic sense.

In the *Soph. Jes. Chr.* the following major points are added: the Savior (Christ) came from the supercelestial region (III 93,8–10; 94,10–14; 107,11–14; 118,15–16). Sophia is the one responsible for the fall of drops of light from the divine realm into the visible world (III 107,16–17; III 114,13/BG 119,9). Furthermore, a god exists who, with his subordinate powers, directly rules this world to the detriment of those who come from the divine realm (III 107,3–11; BG 119,2–121,13). Sex, it is suggested, is the means by which enslavement to the powers is perpetuated (III 108,10–14). But the Savior (Christ) broke the bonds imposed by the powers, and taught others to do the same (III 107,15–108,4; BG 121,13–122,3; III 118,3–25). Two classes of persons will be saved: those who know the Father in pure knowledge (that is, as described in *Soph. Jes. Chr.*), who will go to him; and those who know the Father defectively (III 117,8–118,2), who will go to the Eighth. In addition, it should be noted that the disciples named in *Soph. Jes. Chr.*, Philip, Matthew, Thomas, Bartholomew, and Mary, reflect a tradition within Gnosticism of disciples who are distinctively gnostic, and who are contrasted with some regularity, and in various ways, with “orthodox” or “orthodox turned gnostic” disciples (principally, Peter and John).

The notion of three divine men in the heavenly hierarchy appears to be based on Genesis 1–3 (Immortal Man = God; Son of Man = Adam [81,12]; Son of Son of Man, Savior = Seth). Because of the presence of Seth (although unnamed in the tractate), *Eugnostos* must be thought of as Sethian, in some sense. However, since it is not classically gnostic and lacks other elements of developed Sethian thought, it can only be characterized as proto-Sethian. Egyptian religious thought also appears to have influenced its picture of the supercelestial realm. The probable place of origin for *Eugnostos*, then, is Egypt. A very early date is suggested by the fact that Stoics, Epicureans and astrologers are called “all the philosophers.” That characterization would have been appropriate in the first century B.C.E., but not later. *Eugnostos* and *Soph. Jes. Chr.* may have influenced the Sethian-Ophites, as described by Irenaeus. Some have proposed an influence by *Eugnostos* on Valentianism. Because of the dating of *Eugnostos*, it would not be surprising if *Soph. Jes. Chr.* had been composed soon after the advent of Christianity in Egypt—the latter half of the first century C.E. That possibility is supported by the tractate’s relatively non-polemical tone.

The two versions of *Eugnostos* differ from each other at significant points, attesting a long period of usage. The two versions of *Soph. Jes. Chr.* are very close. The translation which follows is based on the versions of Codex III; the other versions have been employed in instances where pages are no longer extant and where the text has required restoration.